

Crash Model and Deterministic Fault Injection

Learning goal. Understand how the repository simulates crash-stop nodes without killing Akka actors and how tests request failures at precise protocol moments.

Current implementation inspected: `feature/electionTransaction` at `d1222a2`.

Update-category reference: `origin/feat/UpdateTransaction` at `59bbe80`.

1. A simulated crash is a behavior mode

The project does not terminate the Akka actor process. `Replica` instead tracks:

```
NONE -> PENDING -> CRASHED
```

- **NONE:** normal behavior.
- **PENDING:** a test requested a crash after a selected number/type of messages.
- **CRASHED:** protocol receives and sends are ignored.

This models the external effect of a crash-stop replica while keeping the actor address stable for tests.

2. Crash request object

`AbstractReplica.Crash` contains:

- `type`: the protocol point to monitor;
- `after_n_messages_of_type`: the threshold.

Defined categories include:

- `Now`
- `Heartbeat`
- `Update`
- `WriteOK`
- `Election`

The specification needs such instrumentation because failures must be demonstrated not only between operations, but during broadcast, after observation, during commit dissemination, and during election.

3. Immediate crash

For `Crash.Type.Now`, `Replica.crash` moves directly to `CRASHED` and logs it. No protocol event counter is needed.

The actor remains alive and can still receive mailbox messages, including old scheduled events. Protocol handlers and send helpers must check crash state so those messages have no external effect.

4. Pending crash counters

For other categories, the replica stores the request, resets `crashCount`, and enters `PENDING`.

`updateCrashStatusCallback(Msg)` classifies selected messages. When a message matches the requested category, it increments the count. At or above the threshold, it marks the replica crashed.

This creates a deterministic test instruction such as:

Crash after processing/sending the second election-related event.

The exact location of the callback determines whether “after” means before forwarding, after forwarding one message, or after an entire broadcast loop.

5. Incoming and outgoing counting

The callback is invoked in two broad places:

- after the transaction dispatcher successfully delivers an incoming `Msg`; and
- after `broadcast` or `unicast` sends protocol traffic.

Therefore a category can count both received and sent events depending on class and control path. `broadcast` invokes the callback once after iterating destinations, not once per recipient. A crash threshold counts broadcast operations, not individual network enqueues.

This detail must be documented because a test expecting “crash after two recipients” would not get that behavior from the current helper.

6. Current category mappings

On the election branch:

- heartbeat category matches `HeartbeatMsg` and `WatchdogExpiredMsg`;
- `WRITEOK` category currently matches `WriteFinishMsg`;
- election category matches election token, ACK, ACK timeout, rejection, and synchronization.

The update feature branch additionally classifies `UpdateMsg`, `UpdateTimeoutMsg`, `UpdateAckMsg`, `WriteOkMsg`, and `WriteOkTimeoutMsg` as update-category events.

Because the branches are not integrated, the current branch cannot inject every update-stage crash required by the final specification. Also note that `WriteFinishMsg` is a local parent-completion signal, not the distributed `WriteOkMsg`; category naming and mapping should be reconciled in final integration.

7. Ignoring outgoing traffic

`Replica.broadcast` and `unicast` return immediately when status is `CRASHED`. This ensures a queued timer cannot make a dead coordinator emit a heartbeat or continue an election.

`unicast` also refuses self-delivery. Protocol-local notifications that must occur on the owner use direct `getSelf().tell(...)` and therefore need their own crash-aware receive path.

8. Ignoring incoming traffic

`Replica.onMessage`, election entry handlers, and synchronization handlers check crash state. A complete integration must make every special receive handler equally crash-aware; otherwise a message that bypasses generic dispatch can still mutate dead-replica state.

The actor is not removed from membership. Other replicas continue sending until their timeout logic marks it unavailable or elects around it.

9. Timers after crash

Crashing does not cancel every active `Cancellable`. Old ticks and timeouts may still enter the mailbox. Correct crashed behavior ignores them before they send or change externally visible state.

This approach is simpler than tracking and cancelling every timer, but it means crash guards are a correctness boundary. One missing guard can resurrect behavior.

10. Crash-stop versus pause or recovery

The state machine has no transition out of `CRASHED`. That matches the specification: replicas fail by crashing and do not recover.

This is different from:

- a temporary network partition;
- a slow node;
- Akka actor restart under supervision;
- process recovery from disk; or
- Byzantine behavior sending false messages.

Do not claim the protocol tolerates these stronger models.

11. Fault scenarios to demonstrate

A strong exam demonstration set includes:

- 1 follower crashes immediately; quorum update still completes;
- 2 coordinator crashes before phase-one broadcast; initiating replica detects missing `UPDATE`;
- 3 coordinator crashes after some `UPDATES`; election collects freshest observed state;
- 4 coordinator crashes during `WRITEOK`; recovery completes uniform delivery;
- 5 next ring neighbor crashes; election `ACK` timeout skips it;
- 6 best candidate crashes; remaining candidates still terminate;
- 7 stale watchdog arrives after heartbeat and is ignored.

The current split implementation does not yet support every scenario end to end. The gap itself must be recorded.

12. Testing principles

For a deterministic crash test, assert four things:

- the crash was requested at the intended state;
- the expected count was reached;
- no later outbound protocol event came from that replica; and
- surviving replicas reached the required result within a justified bound.

Sleeping and hoping is weaker than observing callbacks/messages with `TestKit`. Time-based assertions should derive from configured latency and protocol hops.

13. Exam rehearsal

Why keep the actor alive after a simulated crash? It gives tests a stable address and deterministic instrumentation while handlers emulate the observable behavior of a dead node.

What is the main implementation risk? A special handler or direct self-message path can forget the crash guard and let a supposedly dead replica act.

The invariant to remember is: **after transition to `CRASHED`, no incoming or queued event may cause protocol output or application-state progress.**

14. A crash is a state-machine transition

```
NONE --crash event--> PENDING --apply at configured point--> CRASHED
|                                     |
+----- normal protocol -----+

CRASHED: ignore client requests, network messages, timers, and callbacks
        until the test/model explicitly restarts or replaces the actor
```

The three categories describe *when* a fault is injected, not three different Java exceptions. A pending crash may allow an already queued event to finish; the crashed state must then block subsequent work. Read the category mapping carefully because feature branches may count “crash after update” at a different instruction than the base implementation.

15. Code microscope: guard every entry point

Checking `crashed` in the ordinary network handler is not enough. Akka actors also receive special entry messages, self-sent messages, scheduler callbacks, and client requests. A useful review table is:

Entry point	What a crashed replica must do
NetworkChannel delivery	ignore without ACK or state mutation
heartbeat tick/watchdog	do not emit a new heartbeat or election twice
client read/write	return the specified failure/timeout, or remain silent
crash control message	transition once; duplicate control is idempotent
queued protocol message	re-check status at handling time

```
void onMessage(Message m) {
    if (crashStatus == CRASHED) return; // central safety guard
    if (m instanceof CrashNow) {
        crashStatus = CRASHED;
        return;
    }
    routeToTransaction(m);
}
```

The real design may distribute these checks across handlers. During review, trace every special path and ask whether it can call a callback or mutate `positions[]` after the status changes.

16. Fault injection as a deterministic experiment

A strong test names the injection point and observes a protocol consequence: “crash coordinator after receiving the third ACK; surviving replicas elect a candidate and preserve the committed epoch.” It is weaker to sleep and assert that “something eventually happened.” Use `TestKit` probes, callback messages, and explicit actor status where possible. Record both what the crashed actor did not do and what the survivors did do.

Practice

For each crash category, choose one message that may complete before the crash and one that must be rejected after it. Explain why the answer changes when the crash is injected before versus after a `WRITEOK`.